

SKOAR! Special



Mass Effect 2

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The Shepard watches over his flock...again

BioWare continues the chronicles of Commander Shepard, humanity's poster child in the science fiction world of Mass Effect. The sequel has one of the more ominous starts to a game with you and your ship being blown to bits. Cerberus—the alleged bad guys from the first game, recover what is left of Shepard's remains and spends two years and truckloads of money to resurrect the Commander. Cerberus shares a common enemy with Shepard and they have a mission for you — saving the universe from Reavers, the antagonist alien race from the first game. When you think about it, the main plot is not a lot different from the first game. The only thing that has changed in the sequel is that your character will be aligned with Cerberus and not the Alliance.

Get a character

The big thing about *Mass Effect 2* (ME2), is that

you can import your character from the first part and continue with it in the sequel. This, for us, is something of a novelty for a console RPG. Unfortunately, an imported character's experience level is reset at the onset and you pretty much start from scratch. Our level 46 Shepard was reduced to a level 2 character and apparently the highest level you can start the game with is level 5; that is if you import a level 60 character. Perhaps to avoid a riot of angry gamers in Edmonton, BioWare decided to give at least some bonus for importing - by way of credits, research resources, and basic weaponry.

The plot

Since Cerberus spent a lot of time and money on putting your pieces together, they pretty much own your ass and the player is not given a choice about working for the people with whom he has fought in the past. The consolation is that it's for

the greater good of preventing a cosmic disaster of epic proportions. And besides it could have been worse; you could be working for the Geth. Despite the catastrophe at the end of the first game, the existence of the Reapers is still not officially accepted; so Cerberus is preparing to wage a secret war and Shepard is their newest recruit. In the first game Reapers used Saren as their pawn and this time it's a race elusive aliens known as the Collectors.

A bulk of the game is about building up a team for an assault on the Collector base. The best thing about *Mass Effect 2* is that you get to assemble a team of ultimate bad-asses from across the cosmos. You can recruit up to eleven members for your team; however this seems a bit excessive since there isn't enough in the core game play to effectively accommodate all the characters. The recruitment missions and the side-quests of each member are short, quick-